

Forgetting Intensity, Remembering Justification: A Developmental Account of Affective Loss

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Abstract

High positive affect is often described as more salient earlier in life, yet its developmental trajectory remains poorly specified. We suggest that this trajectory may partly conceal its own loss, through a reframing of reduced intensity as maturity.

We test this hypothesis using a retrospective paradigm designed to identify a “justification event”, the moment when reduced affective intensity becomes acceptable or is reinterpreted positively. Participants report such events and their timing, alongside measures of affective memory accessibility.

We predict an asymmetry in autobiographical memory: high positive affect is weakly retained, whereas its reinterpretation is more readily encoded. This transition may be biphasic, with a brief detection of reduced intensity followed by a more stable reinterpretation. We further predict clustering of justification events in early adolescence and a dissociation between the clarity of these memories and the inaccessibility of prior affective states.

These findings suggest that developmental change in affect may reflect shifts in accessibility and narrative stabilization, rather than intensity alone.

1 Introduction

Across development, a widely reported yet poorly specified change concerns the apparent decline in the intensity of affective experience from childhood into adolescence. Individuals often describe childhood as a period marked by unusually vivid, immersive, and emotionally saturated states, contrasted with a later mode of experience that is more stable, structured, and moderated. Despite the familiarity of this observation, its underlying structure remains unclear. Most accounts treat this transition as a gradual shift in emotional regulation, cognitive maturation,

or environmental demands (Casey et al., 2008; Steinberg, 2005). However, such explanations leave open a central question: how is this transition represented in memory, and why does it appear both salient and difficult to characterize?

A striking feature of retrospective reports is an apparent asymmetry. While individuals frequently endorse the idea that experience was once more intense, they often struggle to reconstruct or describe these states with precision. Descriptions tend to be vague, metaphorical, or qualified, suggesting limited access to the original phenomenology. This difficulty is consistent with broader findings on the reconstructive nature of autobiographical memory and its limited access to past experiential detail (Conway & Pleydell-Pearce, 2000; Rubin, 2006). In contrast, many individuals can identify a period during which their relation to experience changed in a more structured way. This change is not always described as a loss, but rather as a shift in perspective, often framed positively, in terms of becoming more serious, more realistic, or more mature.

This observation suggests that what is retained in memory is not primarily the high-intensity state itself, but the moment at which its attenuation becomes cognitively reinterpreted. We refer to this as a justification event: a point at which reduced affective intensity is no longer treated as problematic, but is instead integrated into a normative developmental narrative. Importantly, this event is not merely descriptive but evaluative. It involves the active reframing of a change in experience into a sign of progress, consistent with broader work on cognitive reappraisal and meaning-making in development (Gross, 1998; McAdams, 2001).

We propose that this asymmetry reflects the progressive establishment of an optimization-oriented mode of cognition. This mode prioritizes coherence, goal-directedness, and evaluative consistency, and operates through continuous implicit monitoring of actions and internal states. Within such a system, high-intensity, non-instrumental affective states may become unstable or less accessible, as they are sensitive to evaluative interference and monitoring (Schooler et al., 2003). Crucially, rather than being experienced as a loss, this change is recoded as adaptive, and thereby stabilized.

From this perspective, the developmental transition is not only a change in affective intensity, but a change in how such changes are interpreted and remembered. The justification event serves as a cognitive anchor, transforming a potentially disruptive shift into a coherent narrative of maturation. This may explain why individuals often recall becoming “more serious” more readily than they recall what was lost in the process.

This framework leads to several testable predictions. First, individuals should be able to report a temporally localized period during which reduced intensity became acceptable or normative. Second, these reports should cluster within early adolescence, consistent with known developmental transitions in cognitive control and self-evaluation (Blakemore & Mills, 2014). Third, the content of these reports should converge toward a limited set of justificatory themes, including maturity, realism, and seriousness. Finally, there should be a dissociation between the relative

clarity of the justification event and the difficulty of reconstructing the preceding high-intensity states.

The present account extends prior observations on the limited observability and reproducibility of high-intensity affective states. Across domains, a consistent pattern of asymmetry emerges. High-intensity affective states can occur, but are disproportionately difficult to measure without altering their expression (Schooler, 2002). They can be induced, but are not stably reproducible under controlled conditions, as suggested by work on pharmacological and neural stimulation of reward-related systems (Kringelbach & Berridge, 2009; Synofzik et al., 2012). The present account suggests a third constraint: they can be experienced, but are not reliably retained or reconstructed in memory.

2 Methods

Participants

A broad adult sample ($N = 200\text{--}500$) will be recruited online to ensure variability in age, background, and life experience. Participants must be at least 18 years old. No upper age limit will be imposed, allowing the assessment of whether reported events are tied to developmental stage rather than current age.

Procedure

Participants will complete a short online questionnaire probing autobiographical memory of developmental changes in affective experience. The study is designed to avoid explicit references to “joy” or any specific theoretical framing. Instead, questions are phrased in everyday language to capture spontaneous recollection of experiential change and its interpretation.

The procedure is structured to isolate three components: (1) detection of a perceived change in affective intensity, (2) identification of a moment of reinterpretation or acceptance, (3) characterization of how this change is remembered.

Special care is taken to distinguish between the possible initial detection of loss and the later stabilization of a justificatory narrative.

Measures

1. Detection of a Change in Intensity

Participants will first be asked whether they recall a period during which their experience of things became less intense:

“Do you remember a period when things started to feel less intense than before?”

This item aims to capture the possible initial detection phase, without imposing interpretation.

2. Justification Event (Core Measure)

Participants will then be asked whether there was a moment when this change became acceptable or even reframed positively:

“Do you remember a period when you began to feel that experiencing things less intensely was not necessarily a bad thing?”; “Was there a time when this change seemed like part of becoming more mature or more serious?”

These items target the stabilization of a justificatory interpretation. Responses will be recorded as Yes/No, followed by a confidence rating (1–7 Likert scale).

3. Micro-Detection vs. Reinterpretation (Biphasic Structure)

To probe the proposed two-step structure, participants endorsing a change will be asked:

“did you briefly feel that something was ‘missing’, a brief moment before seeing it as normal or positive?”

This item aims to detect whether participants report a transient, less-structured awareness of loss preceding reinterpretation.

4. Temporal Localization

Participants endorsing either a change or a justification event will estimate when it occurred:

“At approximately what age did this happen?”; “If unsure, please indicate a period (e.g., early adolescence, late adolescence, early adulthood).”

5. Qualitative Description

Participants will provide open-ended responses:

“How did you understand this change at the time?”; “What did it mean to you that things felt less intense?”

These responses will allow identification of recurring justificatory themes (e.g., maturity, seriousness, realism).

6. Affective Memory Accessibility (Comparison Measure)

To assess asymmetry in memory, participants will also be asked:

“Can you describe what your most intense emotional experiences in childhood felt like?”; “How easy or difficult is it for you to reconstruct those experiences now?” (1–7 Likert scale)

This provides a comparison between the accessibility of past affective states and the clarity of the justification event.

Data Analysis

Prevalence of Reported Events

The proportion of participants reporting (i) a change in intensity and (ii) a justification event will be calculated. A high prevalence of justification events would support the hypothesis that this is a common developmental feature.

Temporal Distribution

Reported ages will be analyzed using density estimation. The primary prediction is a non-uniform distribution with a peak in early adolescence (approximately 12–14 years).

Age Independence

Correlation between participants’ current age and reported age of the justification event will

be assessed. The hypothesis predicts minimal or no correlation, indicating that the event reflects a developmental stage rather than a recent reinterpretation.

Biphasic Structure

Responses to the micro-detection item will be analyzed to assess the proportion of participants reporting a transient sense of loss preceding reinterpretation. The hypothesis predicts that:
the justification event will be more consistently reported and more clearly remembered
the initial detection phase, if reported, will be described as brief, vague, or less structured

Thematic Analysis

Open-ended responses will be coded using inductive thematic analysis. Expected dominant themes include:

- maturity
- seriousness
- realism
- reduced naïveté

Inter-rater reliability will be assessed on a subset of responses.

Memory Asymmetry

Comparisons will be conducted between:

- confidence and clarity ratings associated with the justification event
- self-reported difficulty in reconstructing childhood affective intensity

The hypothesis predicts a dissociation, with higher clarity and confidence for the justification event relative to affective memory.

Exploratory Analyses

Additional analyses may examine variability in reported timing as a function of contextual factors (e.g., perceived structure of upbringing), as potential modulators of the transition.

3 Discussion

The present account proposes that a common developmental transition is not primarily characterized by a gradual decline in affective intensity, but by a shift in how such changes are interpreted, stabilized, and remembered. The central claim is that autobiographical memory does not retain high-intensity affective states with precision, but instead preserves the moment at which their attenuation becomes cognitively acceptable. This “justification event” appears to function as a durable anchor, organizing retrospective understanding of a broader experiential shift.

A key implication is that affective loss may be systematically masked at the level of memory. Individuals do not typically report a clear sense of having lost something valuable. Instead, they recall becoming more serious, more mature, or more realistic. This suggests that the transition is

not encoded as loss, but as progress. Such reframing is not incidental. It stabilizes the new mode of functioning by aligning it with socially and cognitively valued constructs, thereby reducing the likelihood that the change will be questioned or revisited.

The proposed biphasic structure further refines this interpretation. The transition may initially involve a brief, minimally elaborated detection of reduced intensity, a moment in which experience is implicitly registered as different or diminished. However, this phase appears to be weakly encoded and rapidly superseded by a second phase, in which the change is reinterpreted as normative and desirable. What remains accessible in memory is not the initial discrepancy, but the justification that resolves it.

Within this framework, the emergence of an optimization-oriented cognitive mode plays a central role (Morin, 2026). This mode is characterized by ongoing evaluation, goal-directed structuring, and a tendency to organize behavior and experience around coherence and utility. While adaptive in many domains, such a mode may be structurally incompatible with certain high-intensity, non-instrumental forms of affect. As evaluative processes become more dominant, these states may become less stable or less accessible. Crucially, rather than being experienced as a disruption, this change is reinterpreted in a way that supports the continued dominance of the optimization mode.

This interpretation reframes a familiar developmental narrative. Instead of viewing adolescence as a period in which emotional life simply becomes more regulated or cognitively integrated, it suggests that a specific kind of affective accessibility is lost, and that this loss is rendered acceptable through a process of narrative consolidation. The justification event thus serves both as a memory marker and as a mechanism of stabilization, aligning subjective change with normative expectations of growth.

Several limitations should be noted. First, the present approach relies on retrospective self-report, which is inherently subject to reconstruction and bias. However, the predictions do not depend on the accuracy of recalled affective states, but on the structure and convergence of reported justification events. Second, the temporal localization of such events may be approximate rather than precise. The key prediction concerns clustering within a developmental window, rather than exact dating. Third, individual differences in environment, temperament, or developmental trajectory may introduce variability in both the timing and the presence of such events. These factors should be explored in future work.

Future research may extend this framework in several directions. Experimental paradigms could attempt to induce or disrupt justificatory framing in controlled settings, examining whether reinterpretation alters the perceived value of reduced intensity. Longitudinal studies could assess whether similar narrative shifts can be observed in real time during adolescence. Additionally, cross-cultural comparisons may clarify the extent to which justificatory themes are shaped by social norms versus reflecting more general cognitive dynamics.

More broadly, the present account suggests that developmental change in affect should not be studied solely in terms of intensity or regulation, but also in terms of interpretation and memory. If the loss of certain forms of experience is systematically recoded as gain, then its detection requires indirect methods, focusing on the narratives that make it acceptable. By identifying a specific, reportable event that captures this transition, the current framework provides a tractable entry point for investigating a phenomenon that may otherwise remain obscured.

4 Conclusion

Development may not primarily reflect a gradual loss of affective intensity, but a shift in how such changes are interpreted and stabilized. The present account suggests that what is retained is not the experience itself, but the moment at which its attenuation becomes acceptable. This asymmetry points to a broader constraint: high-intensity affective states may remain accessible in principle, yet become increasingly difficult to stabilize, measure, and recall.

By identifying a specific autobiographical marker of this transition, the “justification event”, this work offers a tractable entry point into a phenomenon that may otherwise remain obscured. More broadly, it suggests that developmental change in affect is shaped not only by experience, but by the narratives that render its transformation acceptable. What disappears phenomenologically may persist only as justification.

5 References

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